

Worksheet 2: My Exposure Hierarchy (The Ladder)

Name: _____ Date: _____ Clinician: _____

Now that we know the obsessions, triggers, and reactions, we build a 'ladder'. Each rung is a situation or thought that brings up distress. We rank them from easiest at the bottom to hardest at the top, then climb slowly - starting low and only moving up when ready. You control the pace.

Ground rules: safety is checked before each exposure. Any exposure involving genuine risk is done with the clinician's guidance and appropriate safeguards. Exposure is meant to raise distress temporarily and safely - not to cause harm.

Rating distress (SUDS)

Score	What it feels like
0 - 20	Calm / only a little uneasy
30 - 50	Noticeable distress but manageable
60 - 80	Strong distress, hard to stay with it
90 - 100	The most distress I can imagine

Listing my challenges

Write each challenge and give it a SUDS score (0-100). Include real-life situations (in-vivo) and facing the thought itself in imagination (imaginal), especially for obsessions with few outward compulsions.

#	Challenge (situation OR thought to face)	In-vivo / Imaginal	SUDS

Ordering the ladder (low to high)

Copy the challenges into order, lowest SUDS at the bottom. We begin at the bottom rung and do not move

up until the current rung feels much easier.

Rung	Challenge	Starting SUDS	Target SUDS after practice
Top (hardest)			
Middle			
Bottom (easiest)			

What I will NOT do during a challenge (response prevention)

List the compulsions/avoidance from Worksheet 1 that you agree to hold back during exposures.

- I will not suppress, block, or push the thought away
- I will not seek reassurance
- I will not avoid the trigger or leave early
- I will not do checking, washing, mental rituals, or 'cancelling out'
- Instead, if distress is high, I will use a safe coping skill: _____

Agreement

I feel ready to start at rung: _____

Safe coping skill I will use if needed: _____

Signed (client): _____ Clinician: _____ Date: _____